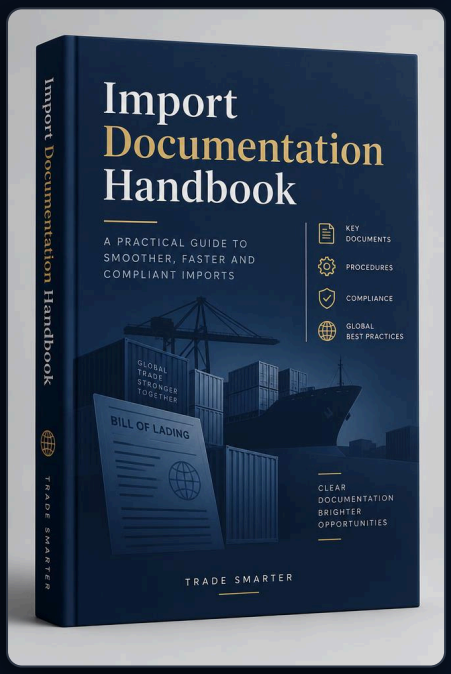
⚓ IMPORTPRENEUR VIP

Practical Workshop Edition • 2026



OFFICIAL EXIM HANDBOOK

Import Documentation Handbook

A Practical Step-by-Step Guide to Smoother, Faster and Compliant Imports

Mentor: Krishnakumar

30 Years Logistics, Customs & EXIM Documentation Experience

Comprehensive Edition

52 Pages • Digital PDF

Table of Contents & Curriculum

1 The Lifecycle of an Import Shipment & Document Timeline

2 Commercial Invoice Structuring & Valuation Clauses

3 Packing List vs Commercial Invoice Discrepancies

4 Bill of Lading (B/L) & Air Waybill (AWB) Operational Nuances

5 Bill of Entry & Post-Clearance Regularization (IDPMS)

🎯 Mentor's Action Checklist & Operational Rules

- ✓ Proforma Invoice verified with exact Incoterm and delivery timelines
- ✓ HSN 8-digit classification validated against latest CBIC tariff notifications
- ✓ Commercial invoice signed and stamped by overseas supplier
- ✓ ISPM-15 fumigation stamp verified for all solid wood packaging materials
- ✓ Prior Bill of Entry filed on ICEGATE prior to vessel berthing
- ✓ Outward remittance reference linked in IDPMS with authorized dealer bank

Confidential & Proprietary Training Material

CHAPTER 1

The Lifecycle of an Import Shipment & Document Timeline

Understanding the lifecycle of an import shipment is the single most critical foundation for avoiding costly demurrage, detention, and Customs queries. Every import moves through four distinct operational phases: Pre-Shipment Planning, Transit & Pre-Arrival, Port Entry & Customs Appraisal, and Out-of-Charge (OOC) Clearance with Domestic Transport. Key Document Timeline: 1. Proforma Invoice & Purchase Order: Generated during commercial negotiations. Must define the exact Incoterm (e.g. CIF Nhava Sheva Incoterms 2020), payment milestones, and technical specifications. 2. Pre-Shipment Inspection Certificate: Required for specified restricted categories or when quality audit is mandated. 3. Transport Document (Bill of Lading or Air Waybill): Issued once the carrier confirms loading. The shipper must ensure consignee details match the IEC legal entity name. 4. Commercial Invoice & Packing List: Dispatched immediately by courier or electronic transmission to facilitate Prior Bill of Entry filing. 5. Country of Origin Certificate (COO): Required to claim preferential tariff duty concessions under Free Trade Agreements (e.g. ASEAN, CEPA, SAFTA).

CHAPTER 2

Commercial Invoice Structuring & Valuation Clauses

Under Rule 3 of the Customs Valuation (Determination of Value of Imported Goods) Rules 2007, the transaction value of imported goods is accepted provided the buyer and seller are not related and the price is the sole consideration.

Essential Elements of a Legally Compliant Commercial Invoice: - Explicit Incoterm: State the 3-letter term and named port (e.g., "FOB Shanghai" or "CIF Chennai"). - Complete 8-Digit HSN Codes: Each itemized product description must be accompanied by its corresponding tariff code. - Currency & Payment Method: Explicit mention of USD, EUR, or INR and the banker LC/TT reference. - Manufacturer & Origin Details: Name and factory address of the manufacturer. - Authorized Signature and Official Seal: Indian Customs will immediately place an invoice on First Check query if signatures or company stamps are missing.

CHAPTER 3

Packing List vs Commercial Invoice Discrepancies

Discrepancies between the Packing List and Commercial Invoice are the leading trigger for Risk Management System (RMS) alerts on ICEGATE.

Rules for an Unassailable Packing List: - Net Weight vs Gross Weight: The net weight on the packing list must tally mathematically with the product quantity on the invoice. - Package Markings: Box numbers (e.g., Box 1/50 to 50/50), shipping marks, container numbers, and seal numbers must match the Bill of Lading exactly. - Package Types: State whether cargo is palletized, wooden-crated (requiring ISPM-15 phytosanitary heat treatment stamp), or in corrugated cartons.

CHAPTER 4

Bill of Lading (B/L) & Air Waybill (AWB) Operational Nuances

The Bill of Lading serves three vital functions: a receipt for goods loaded, evidence of the contract of carriage, and a document of title to the goods.

Operational Variations: - Original B/L: Typically issued in sets of 3 originals. The importer must surrender an original endorsed B/L to the shipping line to obtain the Delivery Order (DO). - Sea Waybill / Express Release / Telex Release: Used when seller has received 100% advance payment. Cargo is released to the named consignee without physical presentation of original bills, saving critical days. - Master B/L (MBL) vs House B/L (HBL): An MBL is issued by the shipping line to the freight forwarder; the HBL is issued by the forwarder to the importer. Always ensure the House B/L is updated in the carrier's Import General Manifest (IGM) before arrival.

CHAPTER 5

Bill of Entry & Post-Clearance Regularization (IDPMS)

The Bill of Entry (BE) is the formal legal declaration submitted to Indian Customs under Section 46 of the Customs Act 1962.

Key Protocols: - Prior Bill of Entry: Can be filed up to 30 days before vessel arrival. Enables advance assessment and duty payment before the ship anchors, reducing port dwell time to under 24 hours. - IDPMS (Import Data Processing and Monitoring System): The Reserve Bank of India tracks all outward foreign exchange remittances against electronic Bill of Entry data transmitted automatically from ICEGATE. Ensure your Authorised Dealer (AD) bank reconciles each payment within 6 months to avoid EDPMS/IDPMS caution-listing.